MINUTES OF THE CLARE COUNTY BOARD OF COMMISSIONERS

Approved 8/19/26

225 W. Main St.
Harrison, Michigan 48625

~~Unapproved~~ minutes
July 15, 2026

Meeting was called to order at 9:00 a.m.

Pledge of Allegiance to the Flag of the United States of America

District 1 Marlene Housler, District 2 Bob Keasey, District 3 Jacob Gross, District 4 Jeff Haskell, District 5 David Hoefling, District 6 Jack Kleinhardt, District 7 Gabe Ambrozaitis, District 8 George Gilmore and District 9 Rick Fancon

COMMISSIONERS ABSENT

None

OTHERS PRESENT

Administrator Lori Phelps, Treasurer Jenny Beemer-Fritzinger, Deputy Clerk Isha Walter, members of the public and zoom participants

APPROVAL OF AGENDA

It was moved by Commissioner Housler, seconded by Commissioner Hoefling to approve the agenda, **Motion carried.**

APPROVAL OF MINUTES

It was moved by Commissioner Housler, seconded by Commissioner Fancon to approve the Board of Commissioners Minutes of June 17, 2026, **Motion carried**.

GENERAL PUBLIC COMMENT

None

COMMUNICATIONS LIST

1. Resolution on Protecting Private Property Rights and Local Control – Clare County Republican Executive Committee
2. Mid-Michigan Veterans Benefit Fair

ADMINISTRATOR'S REPORT

Administrator Lori Phelps took some time to explain transparency, public service and the importance of the public having all facts before drawing conclusions. She clearly stated that she supports the Freedom of Information Act (FOIA) and believes it is an important tool that promotes open government and accountability. Administrator Phelps will begin providing the Board of Commissioners a summary of the FOIA requests received for better understanding of the volume of requests, amount of staff time involved in gathering records, reviewing documents, responding and the cost to taxpayers.

Administrator Phelps expressed concern that at times only part of the information received from a FOIA request is shared publicly without the context of the complete story. Information shared in this manner may suggest wrongdoing or conflicts of interest. She stated that public accountability is essential and should be based on complete information. She remains committed to being transparent and complying to every FOIA request.

ADMINISTRATOR'S REPORT - continued

Lastly, Administrator Phelps announced that she recently received a request from Colliers Engineering & Design on behalf of American Minerals and Fertilizer Corridor – Michigan Rail Reinstatement Project for a letter of support from Clare County. She gathered additional information regarding the project and contacted Representative Tom Kunse's office for further insight. Representative Tom Kunse took some time to provide information to the Board of Commissioners and answer any questions they had regarding the letter of support for the project to reinstall the rail.

PUBLIC HEARINGS/SPECIAL PRESENTATIONS

None

JUSTICE

None

HEALTH AND HUMAN SERVICES

None

PHYSICAL RESOURCES AND ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT

None

FINANCE AND ADMINISTRATION

1. Statutory Finance Committee
   It was moved by Commissioner Hoefling, seconded by Commissioner Housler to approve Statutory Finance Committee meeting minutes of June 22, 2026 in the amount of $219,280.02 and the meeting minutes of July 6, 2026 in the amount of $31,746.66, roll call vote revealed:

   Yeas: (9) being Commissioners Fancon, Gross, Hoefling, Keasey, Kleinhardt, Housler, Haskell, Gilmore and Ambrozaitis
   Absent: (0)
   Motion carried.

2. Monthly Expenditures
   It was moved by Commissioner Ambrozaitis, seconded by Commissioner Hoefling to approve the expenditures for the month of June, 2026 in the amount of $1,894,900.09 with the General Fund expenditures totaling $1,292,567.29, roll call vote revealed:

   Yeas: (9) being Commissioners Ambrozaitis, Fancon, Gilmore, Gross, Haskell, Hoefling, Housler, Keasey and Kleinhardt
   Nays: (0)
   Absent: (0)
   Motion carried.

3. Budget Adjustments
   It was moved by Commissioner Housler, seconded by Commissioner Ambrozaitis to approve Budget Adjustment #26-118 in the amount of $662,759.23, roll call vote revealed:

   Yeas: (9) being Commissioners Kleinhardt, Keasey, Housler, Hoefling, Haskell, Gross, Gilmore, Fancon and Ambrozaitis
   Nays: (0)
   Absent: (0)
   Motion carried.

FINANCE AND ADMINISTRATION - continued

4. Health Insurance Discussion
   Administrator Lori Phelps and Jennifer Martin, a Group Benefit Consultant from The Hilb Group, shared several options in detail with The Board of Commissioners for the upcoming health insurance renewal.

   It was moved by Commissioner Hoefling, seconded by Commissioner Ambrozaitis to conduct a Special Board Meeting August 5, 2026 at 9:00 a.m. to discuss the budget, healthcare and other various items, **Motion carried.**

TREASURER'S REPORT

Treasurer Jenny Beemer-Fritzinger provided all the statutory reports to the Commissioners.

CHAIRMAN'S REPORT

Chairman Gilmore has attended his meetings. He noted an increase in the number of residents in attendance.

VICE CHAIRMAN'S REPORT

Vice Chairman Fancon had no report.

COMMISSIONER'S REPORT

Commissioner Hoefling has attended his meetings and gave a report on each of the townships and committees he represents.

Commissioner Ambrozaitis gave an update on several grant submissions.

Commissioner Housler has attended her meetings.

Commissioner Kleinhardt had no report.

Commissioner Haskell reported that the Central Michigan District Health Department selected a new Health Officer, Janet Erwin.

Commissioner Gross had no report.

Commissioner Keasey reported that he is now Lincoln Township's Compliance Officer.

PUBLIC COMMENT

A member of the public asked if the Board of Commissioners could request a status update from the Secretary of State Bureau of Elections regarding independent penetration testing and certification of the county's voting systems.

UNFINISHED BUSINESS

Administrator Lori Phelps mentioned that the Mid-Michigan Veterans Benefit Fair will take place July 16, 2026 from 10:00 a.m. until 2 p.m. at The CTE John Magnus Center. She also congratulated the Clerk's office for receiving a grant for a portable fingerprinting system.

NEW BUSINESS

None

ADJOURNMENT

It was moved by Commissioner Haskell, seconded by Commissioner Gross to adjourn the meeting, **Motion carried.**

Meeting adjourned at 10:27 a.m.

Isha Walter, Deputy Clerk
Clare County Board of Commissioners

George Gilmore, Chairman
Clare County Board of Commissioners